

The Long RANGER

The successful launch of Agni III plugs the gap in India's nuclear deterrent capability against China

By Raj Chengappa

The tension among missile scientists in the control room at Wheeler Island off the coast of Orissa was palpable. Agni III stood tall on its rail mobile platform—a stubby white and black beast of a missile that glistened in the morning sun. It was developed to be India's primary nuclear weapons delivery vehicle. Among the audience were key representatives of the Indian Army—the users who would initiate steps to induct Agni III if the test proved successful.

The Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) team that had built the missile held their breath as the final countdown began. Despite their confidence, any of the hundreds of the sub-systems could fail, leading to an ignominious end to this five-storey-tall fire breather. It had happened on Agni III's first test flight in July 2006 when super-heated gases from its flex nozzles were deflected back into the motor, incinerating its control systems and sending the missile spinning out of control into the Bay of Bengal. By April 2007 the team had identified the glitch and fixed it by putting a thermal skirt around the nozzle. They then watched with delight



THE AGNI III MISSILE LIFTS OFF FROM WHEELER ISLAND ON FEBRUARY 7